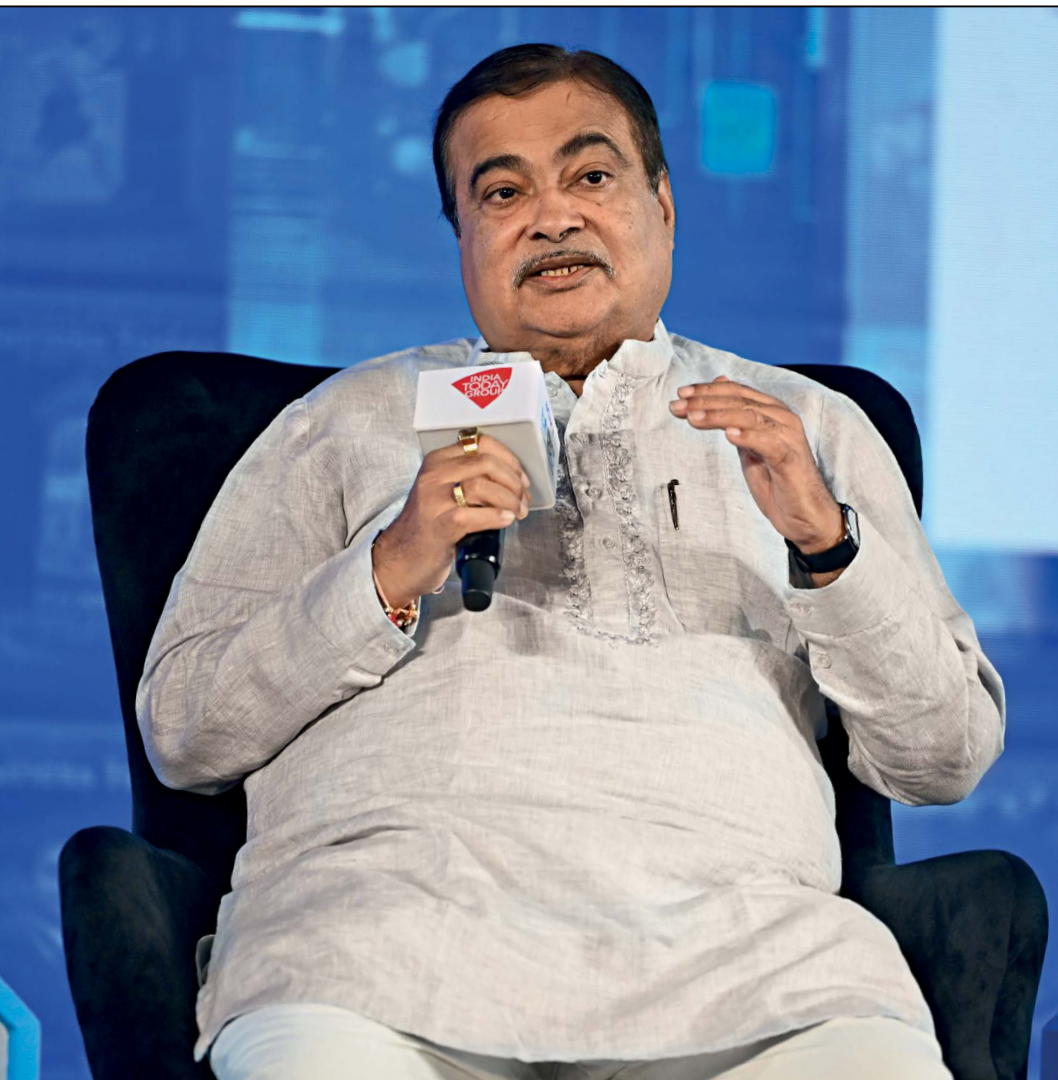




that ethanol does not causes issues.

Is it not better to reduce ₹22 lakh crore worth of imports? Is it not better to reduce pollution in Delhi and other cities? India has surplus rice, wheat, and now corn, which is being used for ethanol. Corn prices rose from ₹1,200 to ₹2600 per quintal due to ethanol demand, benefiting farmers in Bihar, UP, and elsewhere. This

boosts rural agricultural growth. Agriculture contributes 12% to GDP now; we aim to raise it to 22%. Diversification toward energy and power in agriculture will bring great benefits. I challenge anyone to provide evidence of problems with ethanol use. Opposition may be due to vested interests.

At the BRICS conference in Brazil, I saw that 100% petrol, 27% ethanol petrol blends, and 100%

ethanol are sold at pumps. India is moving towards *swadeshi*, self-reliance, and an Atmanirbhar Bharat, exporting energy rather than importing it. Farmers have earned ₹1.14 lakh crore due to ethanol, and the government saved ₹1 lakh crore. Yes, ethanol has slightly lower calorific value than petrol, so mileage drops a little, but as we move toward 100% ethanol, ethanol price is about half that of petrol.



When will 100% petrol ethanol be introduced? You are finalising rules for 27% ethanol blend now.

The 27% blend is still in trial at ARAI. After trials and standards set by the Ministry of New & Renewable Energy, the Ministry of Petroleum will take it to the Cabinet for final approval. But 100% ethanol still has some challenges. When we started ethanol blending, GST was 20%, now it's 5%. GST on 100% ethanol is 18%, which I raised with Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman. Indian Oil has started 350 ethanol pumps. Availability, standards, and compatible vehicles are still in process. Hydrogen vehicles and trucks are in pilot stages, with ₹600 crore already invested in hydrogen projects. Once standards are finalised, implementation will start.



How can we reduce our import dependency on China for rare earths?

I have given suggestions to the mining ministry and PM Modi to reduce the time taken to start a mine, which is currently five to six years due to environment and forest clearances, land acquisition, state and central government rules. The